YEAR 10 PHYSICS, AQA GCSE, LESSON 1 OF 8

PARTICLE MODEL OF MATTER

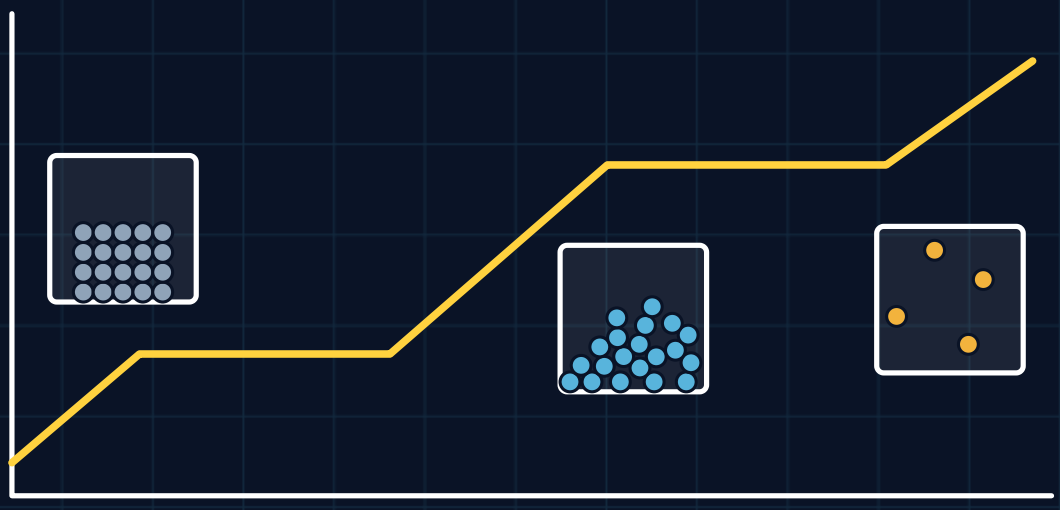
LESSON 01

SOLIDS, LIQUIDS AND GASES

An ice cube, a puddle and the steam from a kettle are all water. What is different about them?

IN THIS LESSON YOU WILL

- draw particle diagrams for a solid, a liquid and a gas
- describe how the particles are arranged and how they move
- name the six changes of state
- explain why mass is conserved when a substance changes state



NAME _____ CLASS _____

TEACHER _____ TARGET GRADE _____

START HERE

HOW THIS BOOKLET WORKS

Everything around you is made of tiny particles. This unit uses that one idea to explain density, melting and boiling, why some things are hard to heat up, and why a gas pushes on its container. Keep the booklet: it is your classwork book *and* your revision guide.

DO NOW

Quick questions from earlier lessons. Remembering again is what makes it stick.

LEARN IT

The explanation and diagrams. Fill in each example from the slides with your teacher, then try "Your turn" alone. Read this again when you revise.

TRY IT

Practice that builds up: first with support, then on your own, then a challenge. Every second lesson ends with the Quick check from the slides.

PRACTICAL

Record your measurements and work out results from them.

EXAM CORNER

AQA-style questions with a tip on how the marks are given.

REVISE IT

Summary, cover-and-answer questions and an "I can" check to colour in.

! **Two kinds of question to know.** When a sentence has a gap, the choices are printed straight after it, like this: The particles in a solid are _____ **(close together / far apart)**. When you see a box of choices, **draw a ring around** the correct one, as AQA exam papers ask. The unit of mass is | **the newton** | **the kilogram** | **the joule** | .

THE ROUTE THROUGH THE UNIT (THIS LESSON IS HIGHLIGHTED)

01 **Solids, liquids and gases**
Particle diagrams, arrangement and motion, changes of state, mass is conserved (slides 3–7)

02 Gas particles and pressure

03 Density

04 Measuring density (required practical)

05 Internal energy and heating curves

06 Specific latent heat

07 Specific heat capacity

08 Measuring specific heat capacity (required practical)

The **equation toolkit** near the back has every equation you have met so far, with formula triangles to help you rearrange. Teaching deck: **panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/particle-model**

Particle Model of Matter, Year 10 workbook: Lesson 1, © 2026 PanPhy Labs. All rights reserved.

Lesson

01 SOLIDS, LIQUIDS AND GASES

AQA Physics 4.3.1.1, 4.3.1.2; Combined Science 6.3.1.1, 6.3.1.2

BIG QUESTION **An ice cube, a puddle and the steam from a kettle are all water. What is different about them?**

BY THE END YOU CAN

- draw particle diagrams for a solid, a liquid and a gas
- describe how the particles are arranged and how they move
- name the six changes of state
- explain why mass is conserved when a substance changes state

particle **solid** **liquid** **gas** **change of state** **physical change** **conserved**

YOU WILL NEED

Demonstration: two sealed syringes (one of air, one of water); a beaker of ice on a balance, covered with cling film.

Teaching deck, slides 3–7
panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/particle-model/#3

REMEMBER

WHAT DO YOU ALREADY KNOW?

From Key Stage 3 and Year 9. Have a go.

1
Name the three states of matter.

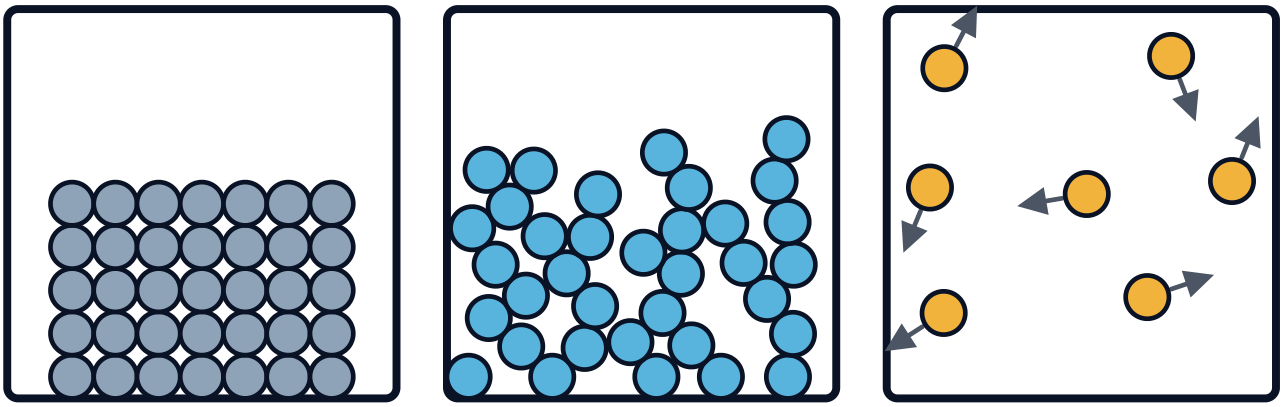
2
Name the change of state when ice turns to water.

3
Name the instrument used to measure mass.

EXPLAIN

ONE MODEL, THREE STATES

Everything is made of tiny **particles** (atoms or molecules), far too small to see. The **particle model** says that a solid, a liquid and a gas of the same substance contain the *same particles*. Only two things differ: how the particles are **arranged** and how they **move**.



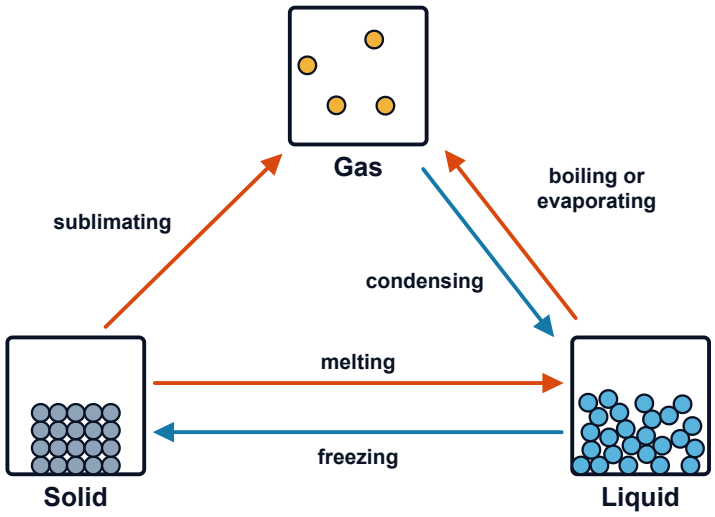
Solid Liquid Gas

Each circle is one particle. In a particle diagram, draw the circles the same size in all three states.

	SOLID	LIQUID	GAS
Arrangement	very close together, in a regular pattern	close together, in a random arrangement	far apart, in a random arrangement
Motion	vibrate about fixed positions	move around, sliding past each other	move quickly in all directions
Shape and volume	fixed shape, fixed volume	takes the shape of its container, fixed volume	fills its container
Can it be squashed?	no: the particles are already touching	no: the particles are already touching	yes: there is empty space between the particles

Get the marks: Draw a solid with the particles **touching**, in neat rows. Draw a liquid with the particles still **touching**, but in no pattern. Leaving gaps in a liquid is the most common mistake in the exam.

CHANGES OF STATE



Orange arrows: the substance is heated. Blue arrows: it is cooled.

A liquid can turn into a gas in two ways. **Boiling** happens only at the boiling point, with bubbles all through the liquid. **Evaporating** happens at any temperature, from the surface only. **Sublimating** is when a solid turns straight into a gas: solid carbon dioxide (“dry ice”) does this.

MASS IS CONSERVED

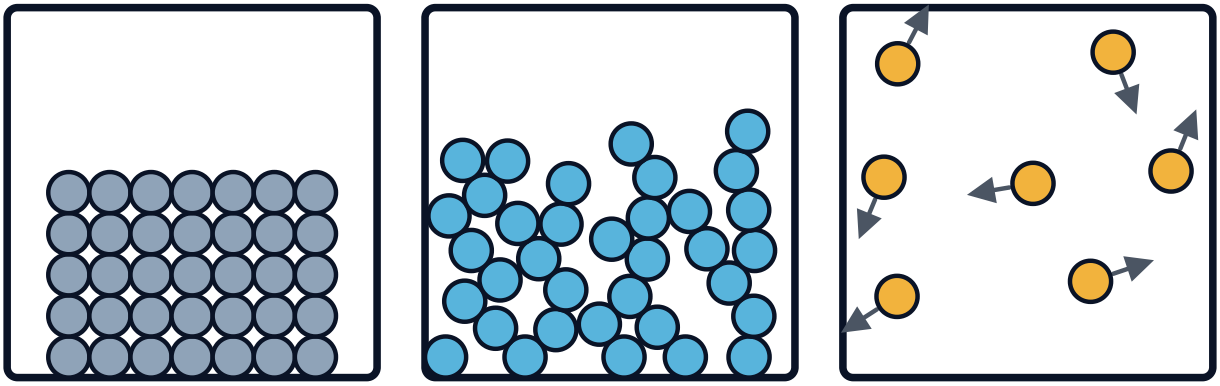
> ! When a substance changes state, **no particles are added or taken away**. They are only rearranged. So the mass stays the same: 50 g of ice melts to make 50 g of water.

A change of state is a **physical change**, not a chemical change. No new substance is made. If you reverse the change, the material gets its original properties back: melt ice and freeze it again, and you have ice again.

PRACTISE

TRY IT

1 The diagrams show the particles in a solid, a liquid and a gas. Write the state under each letter.



A is a _____ **(solid / liquid / gas)**. B is a _____ **(solid / liquid / gas)**. C is a _____ **(solid / liquid / gas)**.

2 Draw a ring around the correct answer in each box.

The particles in a solid

move quickly in all directions	**vibrate about fixed positions**	**slide past each other**

The particles in a liquid are

far apart	**in a regular pattern**	**close together**

A gas can be squashed because its particles

are far apart	**are soft**	**are small**

3 **SUPPORTED** Complete the sentences.

When a solid is heated enough, it turns into a liquid. This is called _____ **(melting / freezing / condensing)**.

When a gas is cooled enough, it turns into a liquid. This is called _____ **(boiling / condensing / sublimating)**.

When a solid turns straight into a gas, it is called _____ **(evaporating / freezing / sublimating)**.

4 Give two differences between boiling and evaporating.

5 A sealed bag holds 120 g of water. It is put in a freezer until all the water is ice. State the mass of the ice, and explain your answer.

6 **CHALLENGE** Liquid water can be poured, but a block of ice cannot. Use the particle model to explain why.

INVESTIGATE

SEE IT: SQUASH IT, MELT IT

Your teacher will demonstrate. Write what you see.

Part 1. Your teacher blocks the end of a syringe of air and pushes the plunger. Then the same with a syringe of water.

7 Complete the table.

In the syringe	Can it be squashed?	What this tells you about the particles
air (a gas)		
water (a liquid)		

Part 2. A covered beaker of ice is put on a balance. The mass is read again when all the ice has melted.

8 Record the two readings and write a conclusion.

	Mass of beaker and contents / g
all ice	
all water	

9 Why must the beaker be covered?

AQA-STYLE

EXAM CORNER

Write in full sentences. Show every step of a calculation.

Get the marks: “Compare” means say something about **both**. Give the arrangement and the motion for each state.

10 Compare the arrangement and the motion of the particles in a solid with those in a gas. **[4 marks]**

11 A student melts 25 g of solid wax in a sealed tube. **[3 marks]**

(a) State the mass of the liquid wax.

(b) Explain why melting is a physical change.

REVIEW LATER

REVISE IT

Use this box after the lesson and before tests.

SUMMARY

- Solid: close together, regular pattern, vibrating about fixed positions.
- Liquid: close together, random arrangement, moving past each other.
- Gas: far apart, random arrangement, moving quickly in all directions.
- Changes of state are physical changes. The mass is conserved because the number of particles stays the same.

COVER THE PAGE AND ANSWER

1 Describe the arrangement of the particles in a liquid.

2 Describe the motion of the particles in a solid.

3 Name the change of state from gas to liquid.

4 40 g of water boils away completely. What mass of steam is made?

I CAN…

- draw and recognise particle diagrams for a solid, a liquid and a gas
- describe the arrangement and motion of the particles in each state
- name the changes of state
- explain why mass is conserved in a change of state
- explain why a change of state is a physical change

REFERENCE

KEY WORDS FROM THIS LESSON

Learn the meaning and the spelling. In exams, precise words earn marks: say “the particles vibrate about fixed positions”, not “the particles shake”.

Particle model: The idea that all matter is made of tiny particles, whose arrangement and motion explain how solids, liquids and gases behave

Change of state: Melting, freezing, boiling, evaporating, condensing or sublimating

Sublimating: Changing straight from a solid to a gas

Physical change: A change in which no new substance is made; the material recovers its original properties if the change is reversed

Conserved: Staying the same in total: mass is conserved in a change of state

CHECK YOURSELF

QUICK ANSWERS

Answers to the “Do now” and “Cover the page” questions, so you can check yourself when revising. Answers to the longer questions are in the answer edition.

DO NOW

1. Solid, liquid and gas.
2. Melting.
3. A balance.

COVER THE PAGE

1. Close together, in a random arrangement.
2. They vibrate about fixed positions.
3. Condensing (condensation).
4. 40 g